TIMEX/SINCLAIR 2068 · DAVID ANDERSON · 2026

SPACE-TRADER

MANUAL

You own a free trader and owe the bank twenty thousand credits for her. Buy low, sell high, and stay ahead of the payments. The cargo that pays best is the cargo customs are looking for.



1 player · keyboard

First edition, 2026



The title screen.

SpaceTrader © 2026 David Anderson. Written with Claude (Anthropic). Released under the MIT license.

Source, tools and build scripts at github.com/factus10/SpaceTrader. The setting takes its shape from the *Traveller* role-playing game, whose free traders are also mortgaged.

Sinclair BASIC + Z80. Code at 49152, data at 50176, font at 53248. Runs entirely in Extended Color Mode. CLEAR 49151 before loading.

CONTENTS

01 Loading 4

02 The screen 5

03 Trading 6

04 The sector 7

05 Contraband 9

06 Heat 10

07 Customs 11

08 Pirates and patrols 12

09 Port services 13

10 The mortgage, and the end 14

11 Tips 15

01 LOADING THE PROGRAM

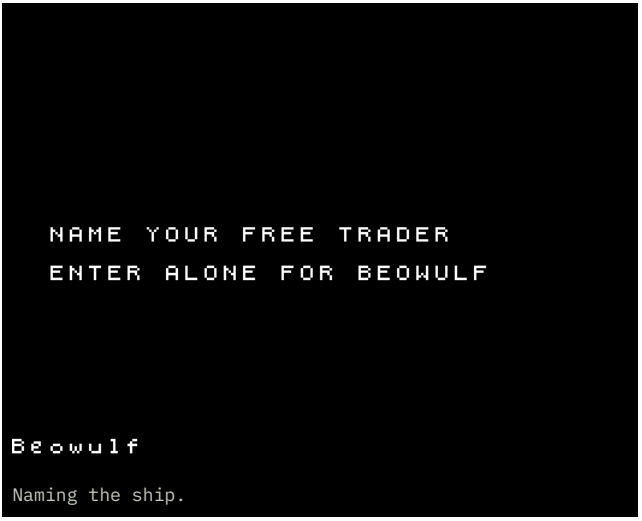
One TAP file of about 110K: the BASIC program, machine code, data, a font, the title screen and twenty system pictures.

1. Set the machine to **TS2068** or **TC2068**.
2. Open `spacetrader.tap`.
3. Type `LOAD ""` and press `ENTER`.

It starts itself. Press a key at the title, then name your ship. `ENTER` alone names her *Beowulf*.

> LEAVE FAST LOADING ON
> The program pulls blocks off the tape as it runs, including a picture for every system you visit.

> DON'T USE RUN
> It starts without reserving the memory the program needs. Let it start itself, or `GO TO 40`.



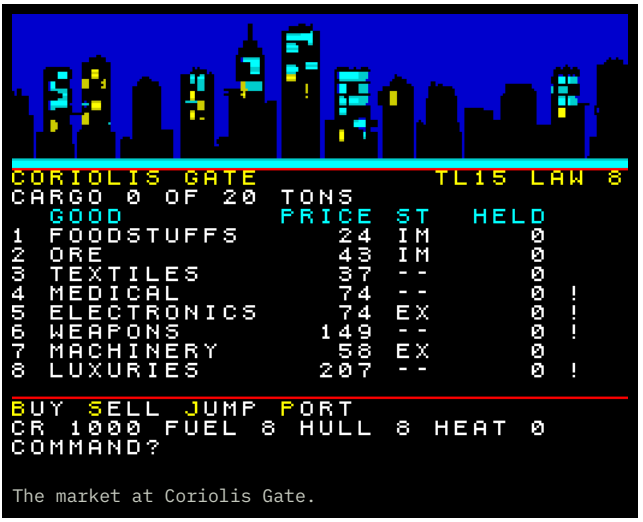
02 THE SCREEN

The top third is the world you are docked at; it changes when you jump. Below it the market, headed with the system's name, **tech level** and **law level** — the two numbers that decide what things cost and how much trouble you are in.

MARK	MEANS	PRICE
`EX`	Port exports it	−30%
`IM`	Port imports it	+40%
`--`	Neither	—

An exclamation mark means that good is **contraband here.** The bottom line is always credits, fuel, hull and heat.

Menu keys show in yellow — press that letter. A message takes the menu's place and shows in reverse; any key clears it.



03 TRADING

Buy where a good is exported, sell where it is imported. That is the whole engine.

Population and tech level shift the price too, and on top of that a swing of up to 15% either way, **rolled afresh every time you dock**. A bad price is worth coming back for. The hold takes **twenty tons**.

GOOD	BASE	ILLEGAL ABOVE LAW
1 Foodstuffs	20	—
2 Ore	35	—
3 Textiles	45	—
4 Medical	90	7
5 Electronics	140	6
6 Weapons	180	4
7 Machinery	110	—
8 Luxuries	250	5

The richest single jump is luxuries from Ambergris into Junction Nine, about 3,400 credits on a full hold. A typical good run pays 1,200.

04 THE SECTOR

Twenty systems. You can jump **within two columns and two rows**, so two squares diagonally is still one jump. Fuel is one ton plus one per two squares — one to three a jump, from a tank of eight.

Core to frontier runs left to right. The core is cheap fuel, cheap repairs and inspectors everywhere. The frontier is the reverse: nothing legal is worth much, nothing is illegal, and the pirates know it.

Ossuary and Vagrant are six jumps out, and **Ossuary connects only through Kalideen**.

```
      CORE <---------------> FRONTIER

        1  2  3  4  5  6  7  8  9 10 11 12 13
 2      ·  ·  3  ·  9  ·  ·  ·  ·  · 20  ·  ·
 3      ·  ·  ·  ·  · 11  ·  · 15  ·  ·  · 17
 4      ·  1  ·  ·  6  ·  ·  ·  ·  ·  ·  ·  ·
 5      ·  ·  · 12  ·  · 10  ·  · 14  ·  ·  ·
 6      2  ·  5  ·  ·  ·  ·  ·  ·  ·  · 16  ·
 7      ·  ·  ·  7  ·  ·  · 13 18  ·  ·  ·  ·
 8      ·  4  ·  ·  ·  8  ·  ·  ·  · 19  ·  ·
```

NO REFUELLING IN DEEP SPACE

Check the tank before a long leg. Stranded with an empty hold and no credits ends the game.

THE TWENTY SYSTEMS

#	SYSTEM	TL	LAW	EXPORTS
1	Coriolis Gate	15	8	Elec Mach
2	Meridian	14	9	Med Elec
3	Verity	14	7	Mach Elec
4	Tessellate	13	6	Lux
5	Aldebar Prime	13	6	Elec Weap Mach
6	Junction Nine	10	5	Mach
7	Hollow Sky	8	4	Food Text
8	Kestrel	9	5	Food
9	Ambergris	11	4	Lux Text

10	Tannhauser	11	5	Elec Mach
11	Fenwick	8	3	Ore
12	Pellucid	12	6	Med Elec
13	Sable Run	9	3	Text
14	Rust Harbour	6	1	Ore Weap
15	Cinder	5	2	Ore
16	Vagrant	6	0	Weap Lux
17	Ossuary	4	1	Ore Weap
18	Longshot	5	2	Ore Food
19	Threadbare	4	3	Food Text
20	Kalideen	7	2	Ore Text

05 CONTRABAND AND LICENSES

Four goods are restricted. A good is contraband anywhere whose law level is *above* its threshold.

GOOD	ABOVE LAW	ILLEGAL IN	LICENSE
Weapons	4	9/20	1,440
Luxuries	5	6/20	2,000
Electronics	6	3/20	1,120
Medical	7	2/20	720

Buying contraband adds 2 heat. A **license**, bought at any port, stops that good being contraband for you anywhere — the exclamation mark goes and customs stop caring.

WHICH FIRST

Weapons is illegal in nine systems and costs 1,440. One core inspection costs more than the license.

06 HEAT

Heat is official attention, and it makes three things worse at once: customs inspect you more often, pirates find you more often, and bribes stop working.

WHAT YOU DO	HEAT
Buy a ton of contraband	+2
Surrender cargo	+1
Pay a fine	+4
Bribe refused	+8
Resist inspection	+15
Every jump	−1

There is no way to pay heat off. The only cure is time: jump, trade clean, let it fall. A run of quiet jumps is worth making *before* a smuggling trip, not after.

07 CUSTOMS

You are inspected on arrival, and sometimes stopped in transit. The chance is the world's law level plus a fifth of your heat, never above 70%. Transit stops are half as likely.

WHERE	BASE
Frontier, law 0–2	10%
Middle, law 3–5	25%
Core, law 6+	45%

KEY	CHOICE	COSTS
C	Comply	40/ton, the cargo, 4 heat
B	Bribe	70% less heat, min 20%. Fails: double fine, cargo, 8 heat
S	Surrender	The cargo, 1 heat. No fine
R	Resist	Fight a cutter, 15 heat either way

Surrender when caught cold — you lose the goods anyway, and it is the fine and the heat that hurt.

08 PIRATES AND PATROLS

Every jump rolls against the law level of where you are going. Heat is added to both chances.

DESTINATION	PIRATE	PATROL	OFFER
Frontier, 0–2	25%	2%	15%
Middle, 3–5	12%	8%	15%
Core, 6+	3%	20%	12%

An offer is a cargo contract worth 50 to 200 credits, paid on the spot. Nobody kills you outright: a fight costs cargo and hull, and the run ends only if the hull reaches zero.

KEY	CHOICE	ODDS
E	Evade	50% + 3 per ton of fuel
F	Fight	Hull vs hull, each + d6
B	Bribe	200 cr, 60% less heat, min 15%
R	Run	As evade

FUEL IS ARMOUR
A full tank escapes three times in four; a dry one about half — and cannot jump away afterwards.



09 PORT SERVICES

Press P at the market. The screen is headed with your ship's name.

KEY	BUYS
F	One ton of fuel
A	Fuel until full or broke
H	One point of hull
L	Trade licenses
M	1,000 off the mortgage
X	Back to the market

Tank and hull both hold eight. Technology sets the price:

TECH LEVEL	FUEL	HULL
15, core	10	40
9, middle	22	64
4, frontier	32	84



10 THE MORTGAGE, AND THE END

You start owing **20,000 credits.** Every eight jumps **800** falls due and is taken automatically if you have it. The port screen shows the balance and the jumps remaining.

Miss one and you are warned. **Miss two and the ship is repossessed.**

The minimum alone takes two hundred jumps. Paying down the principal with `M` after a good run clears it in a handful. The minimum keeps you flying; the profits buy you out.

```
KEEP 800 IN HAND
```
Going into the eighth jump broke is how most ships are lost — not to pirates, but to the bank.

WINNING AND LOSING

Clear the debt and the ship is yours. That is the only way to win.

THREE WAYS TO LOSE

- **Hull reaches zero** in a fight.
- **Two missed payments** and the bank takes her.
- **Stranded** — no fuel, nothing to sell, and not enough credits for a single ton.

The third is the quiet one. Nothing warns you.

11 TIPS

- **Run the core first.** Electronics and machinery out of Coriolis Gate, Verity and Tannhauser pay well and legally, and the core is almost free of pirates.
- **Buy the weapons license before the weapons.** One core inspection costs more than the license did.
- **Watch the market, not the good.** Prices reroll every docking; a 15% swing can beat choosing a different cargo.
- **Fill the tank before a frontier run.** Fuel is cheapest in the core, it is your escape chance, and there is none out there.
- **Let heat fall before the big trip.** It is added to the pirate chance *and* the inspection chance *and* taken off your bribe odds.
- **Surrender rather than bribe when hot.** At 30 heat a bribe is 40% nothing against 60% double fine and 8 more heat.
- **Pay the principal when you can.** A thousand off the debt beats a thousand in the account, because the account is what fines and pirates take.

QUICK REFERENCE

AT THE MARKET	
B	Buy
S	Sell
J	Jump
P	Port

AT THE PORT	
F	Fuel, one ton
A	Fill the tank
H	Hull, one point
L	Licenses
M	Pay 1,000
X	Back

INSPECTED	
C	Comply
B	Bribe
S	Surrender
R	Resist

ATTACKED	
E	Evade
F	Fight
B	Bribe
R	Run

THE NUMBERS	
20	tons of hold
8	fuel, hull
800	due every 8 jumps
20,000	to pay off

timexsinclair.com